

In Parshat Vayaitzei, Leah first marries Yaakov, unknowingly because she was deceived. After Yaakov discovers the truth, Leah tells him (29:27): מִלֵּא שָׁבַע זֶה, and then you can marry Reuven. Following this, Leah marries Reuven, and the story transitions into the story of the births of the twelve sons.

First, Leah gives birth to Reuven, then Shimon, then Levi. When she gives birth to Judah, Leah explains that she gave him that name to express her immense gratitude to Hashem for the blessing of children. She recognized that she had received more than her fair portion, as she had already given birth to three sons. The Pasuk says (29:35):

וַתֵּהָר עוֹד וַתֵּלֶד בֶּן וַתֹּאמֶר הַפֶּעַם אוֹדָה אֶת ה' עַל כֵּן קָרָאתִי שְׁמוֹ יְהוּדָה וַתֵּעַמֵּד מִלֵּדֶת

The Belzer Rebbe, as quoted by Rabbi Oelbaum, asks a powerful question: What is the connection between Leah naming Judah and the end of the Pasuk, וַתֵּעַמֵּד מִלֵּדֶת - that she stopped having children?

He answers that we must always thank Hashem for the immense He does for us. However, our gratitude should also include a heartfelt request for the blessings to continue. When something wonderful happens, we should always say, "Halivai Veiter" - "Keep it coming Hashem!" However, Leah didn't express this sentiment. She thanked Hashem but didn't explicitly ask for more, and as a result, וַתֵּעַמֵּד מִלֵּדֶת - she stopped having children.

To internalize this lesson, we recite in the Shema prayer every Friday night between the words of the Shema and the first verse of the Shema prayer. In it, we thank Hashem for all the He has done for us and express our desire for His blessings to continue: וְאֵשֶׁר אָתָּה עֹתִיד לַעֲשׂוֹת עִמִּי וְעִם כָּל בְּנֵי בֵּיתִי.

From Mama Leah, we learn the importance of always saying, "Halivai Veiter." Whenever something wonderful happens in our lives, we should express gratitude and also ask Hashem to continue bestowing His blessings upon us.

